

on interior walls, as they can resist a lot of washing. Exterior paint is clearly marked and weatherproof. And for your deck, use a linseed-oil-based stain. Unlike clear sealers (which don't block UV rays), the linseed stains drive the pigment deep into the wood and preserve it.

9. What could possibly go wrong?

How about everything? Safety is essential when working on any DIY project, and even if you look like a dope, you need to wear the right equipment. Safety goggles are vital when operating power tools, and hard hats are equally as important when working under scaffolding. If you're painting or using harsh chemicals, open a window or two to keep the area well ventilated. If you're a big fan of those baggy carpenter jeans and old, loose T-shirts, you may want to rethink them. Loose clothing can get caught up in power tools and machinery and the results are none too pretty. Of course, wear a good pair of gloves for carrying wood, metal, rock, or anything else sharp or abrasive. If you're in the basement, follow the safety rules regarding spiders and other dangerous critters (black widows and brown recluses love basements... and one bite can do major damage).

10. A little knowledge is a dangerous thing

A lot of folks just dive right in on home projects. They've seen a Bob Vila show or two, they borrowed a book from the library, and they think they're good to go. That is, until the new addition collapses under their feet. Don't start on your own projects by yourself, and don't start big. If you know someone who happens to be good at this stuff, tag along. They'll be happy for the extra pair of hands on their own project and you're getting valuable experience. Places like Lowe's and Home Depot offer workshops. Take them—they're fun and educational. And when you eventually do start your own little remodeling project, listen to the voice of reason. If you really don't feel 100% sure about what you're doing, step back. You don't want to knock through a supporting wall and end up in traction. — Paul Michael

